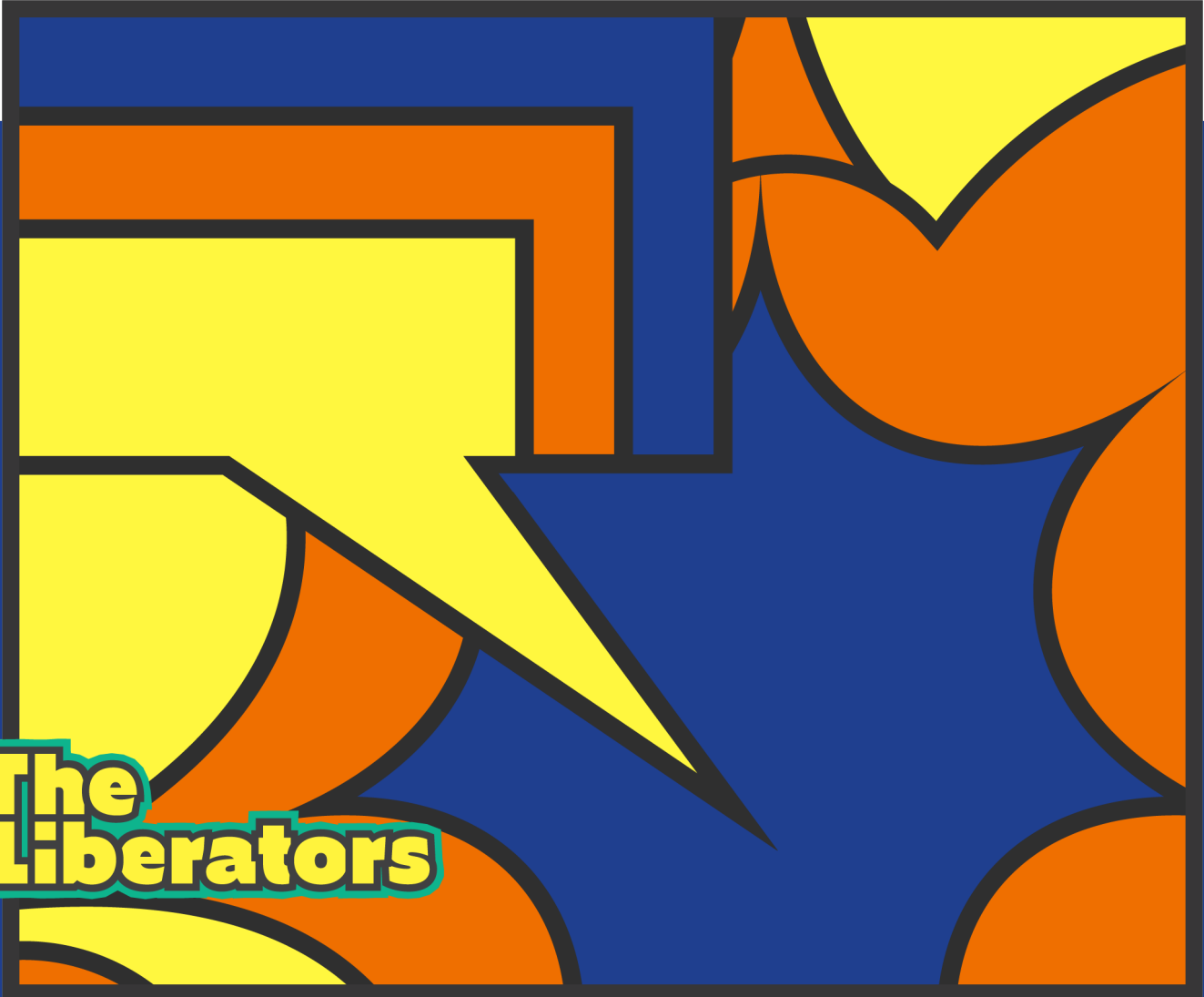


Formulate A Clear Sprint Goal During Sprint Planning

A do-it-yourself workshop to help your Scrum team define a clear Sprint Goal during Sprint Planning with Liberating Structures (e.g. Celebrity Interview, and Min Specs)



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there!

In order to succeed with Scrum, it is important to work with clear goals. Conversely, the best way to end up with Zombie Scrum is to avoid Sprint Goals or to consider them irrelevant or pointless to your situation. If this is happening for you, you're certainly not alone – many Scrum teams struggle with Sprint Goals.

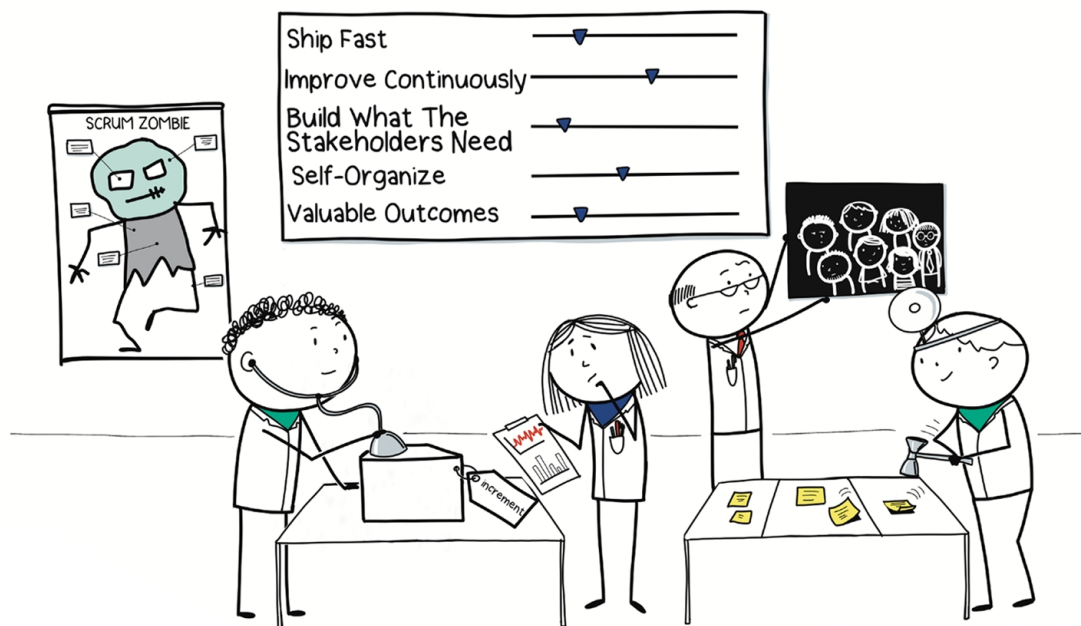
Maybe it is hard for your team to identify a goal for the Sprint out of the patchwork of items on their Sprint Backlog. Or perhaps your Product Owner doesn't know how to balance the requests from many different stakeholders. Whatever the case, many Scrum teams don't use Sprint Goals. And that is unfortunate because Sprint Goals are one of the most effective ways to deal with complex work.

We designed this do-it-yourself workshop to help your team define a clear Sprint Goal during Sprint Planning. The string of Liberating Structures contains Celebrity Interview to clarify the Product Goal, 1-2-4-ALL to select a Sprint Goal, Min Specs to create the Sprint Backlog, and What, So What, Now What to define the Sprint plan.

Give this string a try, and let us know the results!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 5 min

Step 2: Clarify The Product Goal With Celebrity Interview

  25 min

Step 3: Select The Sprint Goal With 1-2-4-ALL

  20 min

Step 4: Create The Sprint Backlog With Min Specs

  25 min

Step 5: Complete The Sprint Backlog And Create A Sprint Plan With "What, So What, Now What"

  30 min

Step 6: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

  10 min

Step 7: Closing

 5 min

Total duration

 120 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



If the Product Owner already has created a Product Goal upfront, spectacular interview skills aren't necessary. Preventing too many detailed discussions can be challenging.

Impact On Survival



A clear, specific, and shared Sprint Goal is a key criteria for a Scrum team to be successful.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward. We've successfully scaled it up to 50 participants (both virtually and in-person) without significant issues.

Intended Audience

This workshop is designed for one Scrum team, which includes the Product Owner, Scrum Master, and the Developers.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor or virtually) where you can collect insights from the various rounds.
- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where all the Product Backlog items are visible
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations. Make sure to clearly include the Product Goal – this is the touchstone for all your decisions.
- Prepare with your Product Owner to make sure that they have a Product Goal they can share, or at the very least the business objectives that are important for the coming months.
- For the Celebrity Interview, find a volunteer to interview the Product Owner. This could be you, but you may prefer to focus on facilitation.



About Sprint Planning And The Sprint Goal

Each Sprint in Scrum starts with a moment where the Scrum team prepares for the upcoming Sprint. This is Sprint Planning. One way to think of Sprint Planning is as the preparation for the hike you'll be going on with your team this Sprint. The idea is not to hash out every excruciating detail, every twist and turn in the route, and every potential problem you might run into. Instead, the purpose is to set the destination, plot a rough route, and make sure you have the right gear – the rest you can figure out along the way.

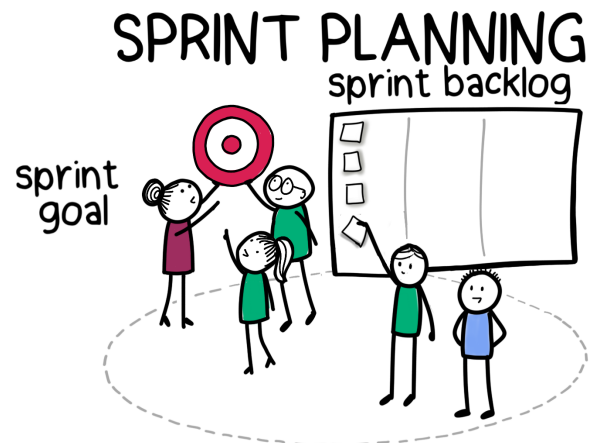
The most important question at the start of a Sprint is what its purpose is: What is the goal? What is your proverbial destination? Without a goal, there is no clear purpose that encourages members to unite and put their minds together during the Sprint. A goal for a Sprint can be to deliver a coherent set of features that solves a particular problem. It may be about addressing a need for a group of stakeholders. It may also be a hypothesis or critical assumption that a Product Owner wants to verify with the Increment that comes out of the Sprint.

Although the Product Owner does well to come into Sprint Planning with an objective in mind, the Scrum team works together to refine this into a goal that is both valuable and feasible within the timebox of a Sprint. The Developers work with the Product Owner to select the work from the Product Backlog that should take place within the Sprint to achieve that goal, reordering the Product Backlog as needed. This selection becomes the Sprint Backlog. Because the Developers do the actual work, they own and have the final say in what goes on the Sprint Backlog.

For Sprints of a month, Sprint Planning should take no more than eight hours. But the shorter the Sprint, the less time it will take. Sprint Planning completes when there is a rough outline for the coming Sprint and a more detailed plan for the first couple of days. This plan is usually captured in the decomposition of work for the first days of the Sprint. As the Sprint progresses, the Developers translate the rough outline – as set by the Sprint Goal and the Sprint Backlog – into a more concrete plan on how to work together to do this. At least one moment to do this is during the Daily Scrum.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum – A Framework To Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Scrum Mythbusters: [A Sprint Goal is Optional in Scrum](#)
- Blog post: [Examples of real Sprint Goals](#)
- Podcast episode: [10 Powerful Questions to create better Sprint Goals](#)



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Created by Tessa Davidson for the ZenHub Scrum Survival Guide
by Christian Vissler, Johannes Gierke, & Tony Chivers

Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then introduce the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Clarify The Product Goal With Celebrity Interview

The Scrum framework encourages the Product Owner to formulate a clear long-term goal for the Product – the Product Goal. The Product Goal gives focus to the work on the Product Backlog by allowing the Scrum Team to commit to a single long-term objective for the product. An inspirational, clear, and tangible Product Goal also makes it easier to define Sprint Goals. It makes sense to use this approach during the very first Sprint Planning, but also when you notice the Product Goal becomes progressively unclear, ambiguous, or vague.

So, we'll start this string by giving the Product Owner an opportunity to share her or his goal for the product. The Liberating Structure [Celebrity Interview](#) is a great way to do this. By using an interview-based approach, the Product Owner can first share their initial thoughts. Then, the audience (the Scrum Team) is invited to ask questions to better understand or sharpen these thoughts.

Invitation

"What questions come to mind that would help clarify, improve, or sharpen the Product Goal?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Prepare for Celebrity Interview by creating a stage where the interviewer (you?) and the interviewee (the Product Owner) are clearly visible from anywhere in the room. You can either position the interviewer and interviewee(s) in front of the room or surround them with concentric circles of chairs. With a virtual session, ask everyone to switch off their camera, except for the interviewer and interviewee.
2. **2 min** Briefly explain the steps of the Celebrity Interview, introduce the interviewer and interviewee, and share how the Product Goal is the primary topic. Also, clarify the expectations of the different roles. The interviewee answers the questions provided by the interviewer. Everyone else is the audience and listens with full attention until step 4.
3. **10 min** The interviewer kicks off the interview by asking questions that exemplify what the audience can ask later. It is super helpful when the interviewer asks for practical examples and potential use cases, instead of abstract ideas. During this session, the primary focus of the questions should encourage the Product Owner to explain and clarify the Product Goal.
4. **10 min** Invite the audience to generate big questions with 1–2–4–ALL and the invitation mentioned above. Give everyone a minute to get their thinking started in silence **1 min**, then pair up with someone else to build on their ideas **2 min** and paired with another pair **4 min**. Ask the groups of four to write their questions down on a (virtual) index card. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms and collect the questions in a chat window or a shared workspace.
5. **15 min** The interviewer collects the questions and sifts through them for patterns. For example, similar questions may appear. Or some questions are more humorous and others are more serious. Based on the patterns, the interviewer asks additional questions to the interviewee(s). It may be tempting to extend the timebox to convey

more information. But with the limited attention span of people, less really is more.

6. 2 min The interviewer closes the interview and thanks the audience and the interviewee (the Product Owner).

Our Findings

- The name for "Celebrity Interview" sometimes puts people off. But Keith McCandless – one of the founders of Liberating Structures – always emphasizes that the name is quite purposeful. The "celebrity" gets a podium to share their view, while also receiving tough and difficult question to sharpen and (potentially) sharpen that view.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Celebrity Interview: Reconnect the Experience of Leaders and Experts with People Closest to the Challenge at Hand](#)





Step 3: Select The Sprint Goal With 1-2-4-ALL

In the previous step, you used "Celebrity Interview" to create a shared understanding between the Product Owner, Scrum Master, and Developers, about the Product Goal. In this step, everyone gets the opportunity to share ideas about what they consider a potential Sprint Goal that would help achieve the Product Goal. Together, the Scrum team select one Sprint Goal.

Invitation

"What is a realistic and achievable goal for this Sprint that allows us to move closer to achieving the Product Goal that the Product Owner just shared? What do we have to say 'No' to?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask the Scrum team to first individually consider a realistic and achievable goal for this Sprint and list the items they have to say 'No' to.
2. **4 min** Invite people to form pairs or invite them into breakouts for pairs if you're doing this virtually. In their pairs, invite everyone to share their thoughts and to develop ideas further, together.
3. **6 min** Invite pairs to find another pair. If you do this virtually, merge breakout rooms. In their groups, ask everyone to share their ideas and to select one Sprint Goal that seems realistic and achievable.
4. **14 min** Each group pitches their potential Sprint Goal to the Product Owner, explains what work they say "No" to, and how everything connects to the Product Goal. Together, the Scrum team selects one Sprint Goal for the upcoming Sprint.

Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- The Product Owner includes the perspective of what is valuable (and what is not) when it comes to the ambitions of the product. So although the creation of the Sprint Goal is a shared effort by the Scrum team, it's a good practice to validate potential Sprint Goals with the Product Owner.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)





Step 4: Create The Sprint Backlog With Min Specs

Now that you have selected the Sprint Goal by which you can move closer to achieving the Product Goal, it's time to create the Sprint Backlog. In order to avoid a massive list of work, it is important to focus your Scrum team on the essential items only. The Liberating Structure [Min Specs](#) is a great structure for this. It invites people to first think as broadly as possible – encouraging all sorts of creative and outside-of-the-box ideas – and then funnels it back down to what is absolutely essential.

About the Sprint Backlog

The Sprint Backlog is the selection of items that the Developers pull from the Product Backlog that they consider necessary to achieve the single Sprint Goal they committed to for that Sprint. The Sprint Backlog makes transparent all the work that a Scrum team is working on or going to work on, in the current Sprint. Each Scrum team has its own Sprint Backlog, even when they work with multiple teams on a single product. The Sprint Backlog is not static and changes as teams learn more during the Sprint. In close collaboration with the Product Owner, Developers may add or remove items based on how much time is left in the Sprint and the relevance or necessity of those items to the Sprint Goal.

Invitation

"What are the essential Product Backlog items we must absolutely complete this Sprint in order to achieve the Sprint Goal?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to individually and silently generate a list of Product Backlog items they consider important to achieve this Sprint.
2. **8 min** Invite people into small groups (3–5) and move them into separate breakouts. Together, they consolidate their lists and expand them to make it as long as possible (Max Specs).
3. **8 min** Bring everyone back to the main channel and explain the next step. Once they're back in their breakouts, ask the groups to test each of the items on their lists against the Sprint Goal. Let them ask: "Can we still achieve the Sprint Goal if we don't complete this item?" Each group removes (or move to a separate workspace) all the items that aren't absolutely essential (Min Specs).
4. **8 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, collect the remaining Product Backlog items on a shared workspace, removing duplicates and clarifying as needed. The result is a list of items that are absolutely necessary in order to achieve the Sprint Goal.

Our Findings

- We often encourage teams to generate more items for the "Max Specs"–part. This drives more creative and less-obvious items that may end up being super important. At the same time, we always encourage teams to be more minimalistic during the "Min Specs"–round
- The Product Owner is accountable for maximizing the value of the product resulting from the work of the Scrum team. The Product Owner is also accountable for effective Product Backlog management, which includes ordering Product Backlog items. It's an excellent practice to make ordering the Product Backlog a shared activity by the entire Scrum team. But always make sure to inform the Product Owner about the changes being made.
- Don't worry if you can't relate all the items on a Sprint Backlog directly to the Sprint Goal. Sometimes, there may be a compelling reason to do some work this Sprint even though it doesn't align with the Sprint Goal (e.g. a planning issue or an external dependency). Be skeptical of accepting such work though, and ask "What is lost if we do this next Sprint?" or "How we will make sure to keep the focus on the Sprint Goal?";

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "Min Specs" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Use 'Min Specs' to help groups discover what is absolutely essential](#)



Step 5: Complete The Sprint Backlog And Create A Sprint Plan With "What, So What, Now What"



In the previous step, the Scrum team selected the essential Product Backlog items that they must absolutely complete this Sprint in order to achieve the Sprint Goal. It could be that some items are considered important, but not essential, and they didn't make it to the Sprint Backlog. With the Liberating Structure [What, So What, Now What](#) the Scrum team will reflect on the Sprint Backlog they created so far, determine what's missing, and make a plan for the upcoming days. This isn't a detailed plan that can't change. It's simply to have a shared understanding of how to get started.

This Liberating Structure uses three consecutive rounds of sense-making, each starting with a moment of individual reflection followed by a brief 4-minute conversation in the small groups and a shared conversation of 8 minutes.

Invitation

Round 1: "When you study the Sprint Backlog we created, what do you notice? What seems to be missing? What does your gut feeling tell you?"

Round 2: "So, what does this mean for our ability as a team, to have a successful Sprint?"

Round 3: "Now, what needs to be added, removed, or re-ordered from the Sprint Backlog?"

Steps

Round 1: Observations

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the first invitation. When they study the Sprint Backlog, what do they notice? What seems to be missing? What does their gut feeling tell them?
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2-4 people) and to share what they noticed. Encourage them to focus on patterns.
3. **8 min** Together, ask each group to share one observation that they feel is most important to their work together. Capture (other) observations on a shared workspace.

Round 2: Conclusions

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the second invitation. So, what does this mean for our ability as a team, to have a successful Sprint?
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2-4 people) to share their conclusions on what seems important. Encourage them to notice patterns.
3. **8 min** Together, ask each group to share one conclusion that they feel is most important. Capture (other) conclusions on a shared workspace.

Round 3: Adaptations

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the third invitation. Based on the conclusions drawn, what needs to be added, removed, or re-ordered in the Sprint Backlog?
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2-4 people) to share their ideas about how to move forward and necessary adaptations to the Sprint Backlog. Encourage them to notice patterns.
3. **8 min** Together, ask each group to share one idea or thought that they feel is most important. Capture (other) ideas and adaptations on a shared workspace.



Our Findings

- In order to avoid the influence of personal biases and office politics, it is helpful to focus Round 1 on data-driven observations. For example, "I feel the Sprint Backlog contains way too many items" is not an observation but an opinion. To get at the observation, you can ask: "What makes you say the Sprint Backlog has too many items?".
- Most of us tend to jump to conclusions without weighing the facts. This means that "What, So What, Now What" is often hard and counter-intuitive the first few times you do it. But if you explain its purpose, and why you do it as part of Sprint Planning, it will become second nature over time.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Create shared understanding with 'What, So What, Now What'](#)



Step 6: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

In the previous step you used What, So What, Now What to complete the Sprint Backlog. In this closing exercise, the Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#) is used to have each team member determine their personal next steps.

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to help the Scrum team achieve the Sprint Goal? What is an item from the Sprint Backlog you can start working on immediately after we finished Sprint Planning?"

Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partners find ways to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"
- You can make individual 15% Solutions transparent on your virtual whiteboard. But make sure that this is optional.

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

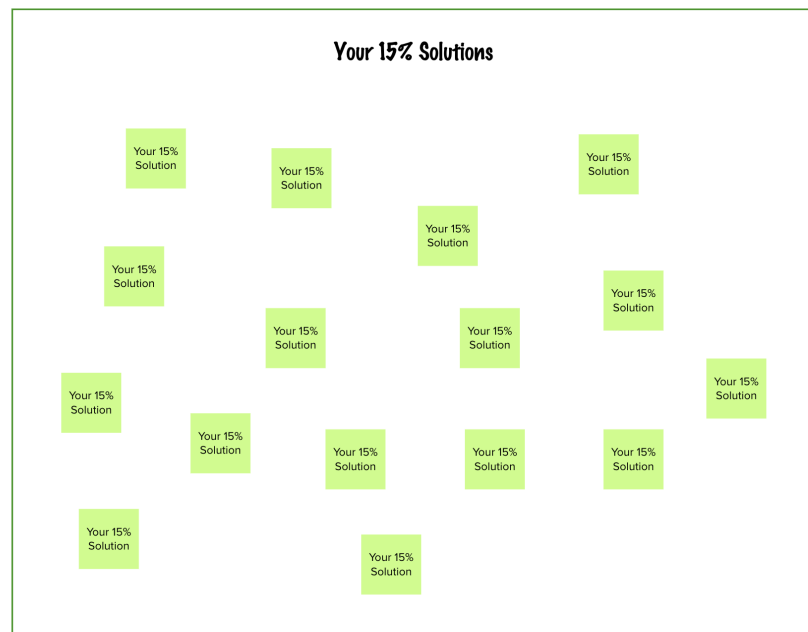
Step 1

Position yourself in the scenario you recognize the most and write down a personal next step.

What is an improvement that you can make, without needing approval from someone else or resources you don't have access to?

Step 2

Pair up and share your 15% Solution while giving and getting help to refine your next step



Step 7: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this gathering?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

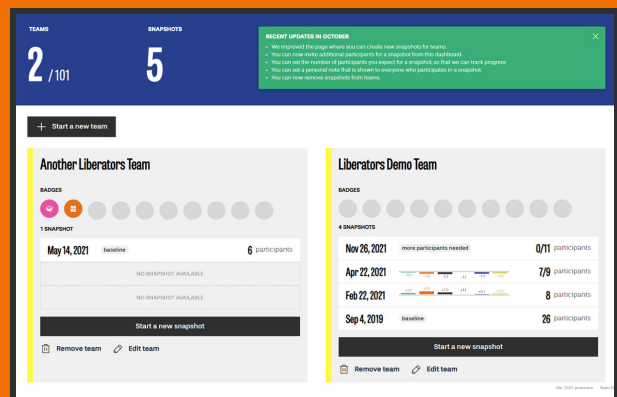
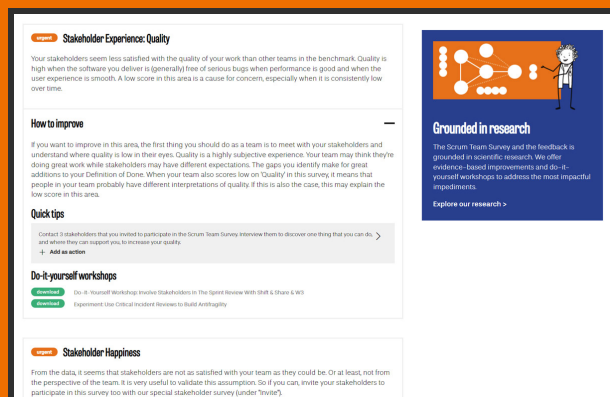
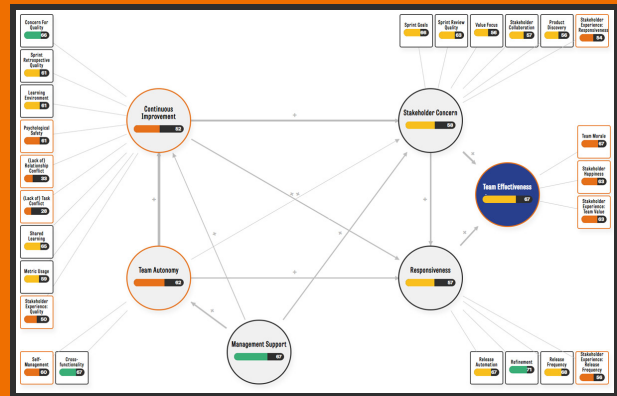
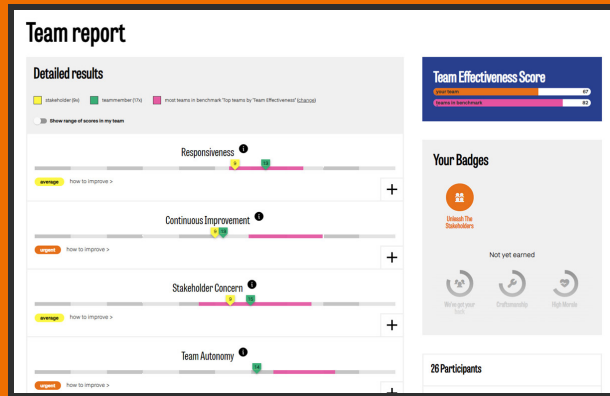
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

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